

Think College Learn

Podcast Transcript

Job Development Module

Welcome to this think college live podcast! Think College provides training and technical assistance, conducts research, and engages in comprehensive dissemination of resources in the area of postsecondary education for people with intellectual disabilities.

Today's podcast features **Amy Dwyer**, a Senior Associate and job development specialist from TransCen Incorporated. In this podcast Amy discusses some of the key strategies to prepare students for jobs. In particular, she looks at the challenge of employment for students with intellectual disabilities and how job developers can build a bridge with employers by considering specific marketing strategies.

(Amy's bio link: <http://www.thinkcollege.net/about-us/staff-bios>)

MUSIC INTERLUDE

Transcript from Podcast by Amy Dwyer

As someone tasked with finding meaningful jobs for students with ID in a postsecondary program, *you are a salesperson*. Your job is to sell a '**product**,' which are your qualified job candidates, and sell a '**service**,' which is on-the-job consulting you provide at no cost, to a **targeted audience** (which in this case is employers who need assistance filling their hiring needs). It is that simple.

But it is really only that simple if you know some basic sales and marketing strategies. The difference between a **GOOD SALESPERSON** and a **BAD SALESPERSON** is often very clear – and we have all been customers who have experienced both.

One of the biggest signs of **BAD SALESPEOPLE** is not having enough knowledge about the **PRODUCT** they are selling.

Learning Activity Section

This Learning Activity section will take you back to the basic beginning steps of job developing – steps that are often overlooked or more likely underutilized: The student DISCOVERY and ASSESSMENT process. (This is getting to know your product) and then the SELLING of your STUDENTS (developing your individualized marketing scripts that you can take out to an employer.) And because you are working with students who are in a postsecondary program, who are accessing a number of unique environments and are open to a whole new world of opportunities, your job actually becomes easier and more interesting!

So how do you get all the information you need about a student to really make you feel prepared to go out and sell him or her? The best way is to gather info from a variety of sources.

Remember two things:

1. First, everyone acts differently in different situations and environments. For example, we do not act the same way with our bosses at a Monday morning meeting as we do when we go out with friends on a Saturday night! We **adapt** to our environment, our surroundings, and our situation.
2. And second, everyone's responses to questions you ask about a student are **THEIR OWN OPINIONS** and **PERSPECTIVES**, so you need to balance those answers with your own observations – what a teacher sees a student do is different than a college mentor might see them do, so responses will be different. The most effective way to get the best and most realistic picture of a student is to gather from a bunch of sources and look for themes.

How to Collect Student Information

What are some of these ways to collect information? There is **one-on-one** interviews with the student, which works best with students who are **verbal** and like to express information about themselves:

- observations in a college classroom
- review of any files on the student
- observation on a job or doing job tasks
- interviewing teachers or other professionals who have worked with the student
- interviewing family and friends
- observing at home, which is a different environment
- paper and pencil tests
- computer tests
- career assessment tests

Each student responds differently to those but you can get some good information. Observation in the college community, observation in the general community, and even work simulations.

After this process you will end up with a huge amount of information. So how do you use it?

How to use this information

When you meet an employer, imagine introducing a student as someone who has an Intellectual Disability with odd behaviors and anxiety triggered by criticism but managed by medication, has an IQ of 63 and a low adaptive skills score, can file by first letter alphabetically in the English Department office but scores high in 'working with her hands'

on the ABC Career Interest Inventory, loves fish fry day in the campus café on Fridays, will break into dance in the middle of a store if a song she likes comes on, and yells at her mom but is afraid of her dad.

This is all information you gathered about the student – but it is not all MARKETABLE information helpful for an employer in deciding whether to hire!

It is your job to sift through the raw data and pull out the information that is useful to an employer – in other words, what translates into a **'description of a good worker.'**

One way to do this is to create a **Positive Personal Profile (PPP)**. This process helps you to categorize all the information into a dozen positively-focused topics that are then more easily translated into **'sellable characteristics of a good worker.'** It also helps you to avoid focus on the negative information you may have uncovered, and instead turns them into **'areas that need support;'** they cannot be ignored, but they also should not be the sole focus or part of your selling speech.

Keep in mind, to know exactly what each employer thinks is a 'good worker,' and to learn which exact *skills* and *characteristics* are needed for a specific job, you will have to research businesses as well so you can match the right student to the right job.

The areas focused on in a positive personal profile include **dreams and goals, interests of the students, talents, skills, and knowledge** (stuff that they already bring to the table), **learning styles** (how best do they learn?), **values, positive personality traits** (characteristics that their friends would describe them as having), **environmental preferences** (do they want to work indoors? Outdoors? Alone? In a team?), **dislikes** (areas to avoid), **life and work experiences, support system, specific challenges** (this could be related to their disability or also could be related to a family situation, anything that creates a challenge that you are aware of) and creative solutions and accommodations to those challenges.

Now you're armed with a lot of information.

How to Market your Product

Your job is to market your students. Once you collect all the information you can about a student, you must now *sift through* it all in order to **create a picture of that student that is appealing to a specific employer**.

The first step is to recognize that your students have strengths and weaknesses. Pulling out strengths is easy; dealing with weaknesses is trickier. You can't ignore a student's challenges or weak points. On the contrary, you must be very aware of them and already have **solutions** in place to overcome them the best way possible. But there are issues that you

cannot sell to an employer as you begin your student marketing. You need to learn to **turn some of those deficits into Assets**.

For example, what is listed in the file as 'antisocial behavior' could be translated into 'very focused on the job' and 'not chatty/will not waste time socializing on the job.' There are ways of turning deficits into assets for employers.

Once you have gone through the first several steps of **Discovery and Assessment** – the gathering of information from many sources, the completion of a Positive Personal Profile, and the turning of deficits into assets, you are ready to create your “**Marketing Script**.” This will guide you through selling your student to an employer.

How to Create Your Marketing Script

There are several steps to this process, but if you hit each of them, the whole process becomes easy and fun. Your first step is to simply **list all of your student's best features** – characteristics that appeared on the positive personal profile, cool remarks and quotes from people you interviewed, awards and commendations from the student's file, etc. These are all things that make the student look really good.

The next step is to **target which employers you want to approach**; always know who you are approaching ahead of time because you will need to do some research about each business. How do you figure out which businesses to hit?

How do you know which Businesses to apply to?

Start with the **interests and strengths** that appeared about your student in the Positive Personal Profile: if a student loves animals, try pet stores or vet offices; if a student loves working outdoors, look for landscaping companies, etc. Then move on to geographical locations and your student's transportation limitations, and find businesses he or she can get to as independently and consistently as possible. It makes your life and the student's life easier.

Once you target a business, **do a little research**: check out their website to see what they are looking for in employees, visit the location as a customer to get a feel for the culture, etc.

The final step is to match the sellable features of the student with the needs of the business you are selling to. The easiest way to do this is to use a strategy called **Features to benefits**. It's a classic marketing strategy and I will illustrate it with a story about a car salesman; a story that actually happened to me.

I needed to buy a car in the city I had moved to, my dad wasn't there to help me. I knew exactly what I wanted but the one thing my dad had said, “do not buy the first car you test drive because your car right now isn't so great. Any car is going to feel better.” I realized I needed to shop around, so I started at a Volkswagen dealership.

Case: Features to Benefits

Here is a classic story about a Car Salesman that illustrates this: A young woman needed to buy a car and wanted to shop around. She started at the Volkswagen dealership, where she explained what she thought she was looking for: She drives all day for work in the city, transporting students to job interviews. She often needs to park on the street, and she also has 2 big dogs she likes to take hiking on weekends.

I explained what I needed when I walked in the door. I explained I drive all day for work in the city, I transport lots of students to job interviews, I often need to park in the street in the city, park on the street in front of my apartment, and I also have two big dogs that I like to take with me hiking on weekends. And then I gave a price range. This car salesman said, "I have the perfect car for you." He took me over to the Jetta and said, "it's sporty, has 12 new colors this year, and my wife and daughters drive this car; it's the perfect car for you." So I test drove it and it felt great, but I remembered my dad saying not to buy that first car.

I then walked into the Subaru Dealership using the same description of what I was looking for- my driving in the city, the two dogs...etc. The Subaru Dealer responded, "I changed my mind about what car I was going to tell you about. When you first walked in, I had an idea of what you needed, but after listening to you, I think the Subaru Outback Sport is the perfect car for you and this is why: it's shorter than the regular Outback which is better for city driving, easier to park, and better to get around in traffic. It gets good gas mileage, which is helpful for city driving. It's a 4-door car, so you don't have to get out of your car, fold the seats, let the students climb in the back, fold them again, get back in the car, close the door, which can be a real pain. It's also a hatchback so that both dogs can get in the back with the seats folded down, get the dog hair all over that, fold it back up and there's no dog hair in the back seat. So when you pick up students again, they aren't sitting in dog hair and covered in dog hair for their interviews. It's also good for taking dogs hiking because it's all wheel drive and it handles the snow much better which is important when students are in the car.

You can see the difference between the first salesman and the second salesman. The first salesman didn't listen to a word I said. He had in his head that any female who walked in, he would sell them the Jetta. If I had walked in and said I was looking for a car that had 12 sporty new colors this year and that your wife and daughter drive, then he really would have had the perfect car for me. Instead the second salesman listened to everything I said and then turned the feature of that Subaru Outback Sport, every single feature of that car, into a benefit to me. So you can imagine I bought the Subaru Outback Sport. That is what you need to learn to do, is take the features of your student, and market them as benefits to a specific employer.

Using the Marketing Script for the Interview

Now you have all the basics for a Marketing Script: You have a list of all your student's best working features, as well as all the ways those characteristics can benefit that employer. After you've developed some rapport with an employer and are at the point where you are ready to make your sell, you have very convincing arguments!

I never recommend that job developers write out an exact script of what you will say – this can lead to a stilted or over-prepared presentation and may make you uncomfortable. But go ahead and take in the Features to Benefits chart filled in and it will be very easy for you to talk from that information – like you have “**Talking Points**” right in front of you. Some people even present that chart directly to the employer and work through it together.

If you have a student who is capable of selling herself to an employer, you can work with her to use this Features to Benefits chart to answer interview questions and really sell herself during a job interview as well. When a student can talk very clearly about her strengths AND how they apply to the job she is specifically interviewing for, it is a very powerful interview. If you can do that for a student as well, it's a really easy sell. A lot of this information has additional resources on the **Think College! Employment Module** that support this process. This is the way to get your foot in the door and feel confident about selling your students.

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Thank you so much for listening to this TCLIVE podcast. Stay tuned for more podcasts coming soon. For more about our resources and projects, go to www.thinkcollege.net